

DYNAMIC FAMILIES FROM MESSED UP TO RAISED UP!

TEXT: John 20:1-10 (NKJV) *“Now on the first day of the week Mary Magdalene went to the tomb early, while it was still dark, and saw that the stone had been taken away from the tomb. 2 Then she ran and came to Simon Peter, and to the other disciple, whom Jesus loved, and said to them, “They have taken away the Lord out of the tomb, and we do not know where they have laid Him.” 3 Peter therefore went out, and the other disciple, and were going to the tomb. 4 So they both ran together, and the other disciple outran Peter and came to the tomb first. 5 And he, stooping down and looking in, saw the linen cloths lying there; yet he did not go in. 6 Then Simon Peter came, following him, and went into the tomb; and he saw the linen cloths lying there, 7 and the handkerchief that had been around His head, not lying with the linen cloths, but folded*

together in a place by itself. 8 Then the other disciple, who came to the tomb first, went in also; and he saw and believed. 9 For as yet they did not know the Scripture, that He must rise again from the dead.”

INTRO: It's Resurrection Sunday! That is what Easter is all about. It is about a loving Heavenly Father so concerned about our sin-sickened state that He sent His Son, Jesus, to defeat sin and death through His cross and resurrection.

Just three days prior, Jesus had been falsely accused, tried and unfairly convicted. He was sentenced to the cruel death of the cross.

Shockingly, this was all God's pre-determined plan, His way to bring salvation to us.

Jesus willingly bore our sins. Imagine standing in a court, guilty and rightfully convicted, but then one stands up to voluntarily pay the fine

and take our place. How would we feel toward such a man? That's Jesus!

Jesus not only took our punishment, He also demonstrated His power by taking up His life on the third day. He lives now to:

- Pray for us...
- Guide us...
- Heal us...
- Deliver us...

And He is coming again to gather us!

Resurrection is about that first Easter but it is about far more than that. Easter or resurrection should be on display all day, every day and in every way, for those who are Christ followers.

Over the next four weeks we are going to learn about a family that wandered away and suffered great loss, but through the redemptive plan of

God experienced restoration and new life, may I say, resurrection life!

Ruth 1:1-6 (NKJV) *“Now it came to pass, in the days when the judges ruled, that there was a famine in the land. And a certain man of Bethlehem, Judah, went to dwell in the country of Moab, he and his wife and his two sons. 2 The name of the man was Elimelech, the name of his wife was Naomi, and the names of his two sons were Mahlon and Chilion Ephrathites of Bethlehem, Judah. And they went to the country of Moab and remained there. 3 Then Elimelech, Naomi’s husband, died; and she was left, and her two sons. 4 Now they took wives of the women of Moab: the name of the one was Orpah, and the name of the other Ruth. And they dwelt there about ten years. 5 Then both Mahlon and Chilion also died; so the woman survived her two sons and her husband.”*

This story takes place in the time of the Judges ... a period around 1,300 B.C. when various leaders, or judges, ruled in Israel.

First, we note that there was a famine in the land of Israel. Bethlehem means “*The house of bread.*”

The famine became an external stressor that provoked an improper reaction from Elimelech. External stressors often have this effect. This is why it is so important to have a person of faith leading the household.

The improper reaction was to move to the land of Moab. Moab was the perennial enemy of Israel. They oppressed Israel for 18 years at a different point in time during the period of the Judges, and were well known for their worship of the god Chemosh. The followers of Chemosh practiced human sacrifice!

It is into this place – into a worldly place – that Elimelech sought refuge in his desperation. Can you imagine making a decision to take your family into such a place?

Most likely, Elimelech planned to stay in Moab only a short time. He had ancestral lands in Israel, a home, a social network and surely he meant not to permanently forsake those blessings and benefits. Gentlemen, the consequences of how we lead our families are going to eventually be laid at our feet.

The world (Moab) will always:

- Take us further than we intended to go...
- Keep us longer than we intended to stay...
- Extract from us far more than we intended to pay...

A family of four made the trip to Moab, Only one returned!

Moab became a place of death for the family of Elimilech. Upon her later return to Israel, Naomi declares, Ruth 1:21(NKJV) ***“I went out full, and the Lord has brought me home again empty.”*** Remember they left Bethlehem because of a famine! Ten years of living in the world changed her perspective. I paraphrase this Scripture as follows ***“The worst day at church is better than the best day in the world.”***

Sometime after her husband and sons had died, Naomi heard while in Moab that, Ruth 1:6 (NKJV) ***“The Lord had visited His people (Israel) by giving them bread.”***

Though God’s people may see seasons of leanness, God always visits in due time with His provision.

I’m going to skip over some details today, because over these next three Sundays we are

going to learn from this book of Ruth how to carry ourselves as husbands, as wives, and how to see the next generation, our kids, restored.

While in Moab:

- Elimelech died...
- The two sons died...
- Naomi encouraged her daughters in law to remain in Moab while she returned to Bethlehem...
- Ruth, decided to accompany her mother in law to Bethlehem saying, ***“wherever you go I will go... Wherever you lodge I will lodge... Your people shall be my people... Wherever you die I will die...”***
- Ruth went to work in the field of Boaz who was a near relative to Elimelech...
- Boaz noticed Ruth...

There existed a law in those days that if a man died, his nearest male relative was to marry the

widow and through that union to produce heirs to continue the family name and inheritance of the land.

Ruth's diligence and devotion to her mother-in-law won her the respect and love of Boaz, who upon her request exercised this right of a near relative or "kinsman." He married Ruth and through this union restored the fortunes and the generations to the family of Naomi.

The book of Ruth closes with this, Ruth 4:21 (NKJV) "***Boaz begat Obed; Obed begot Jesse, and Jesse begot David.***"

Boaz and Ruth became the great grandparents of David, Israel's second king and Jesus came to us through the line of David.

The author tells us that Boaz was a man of virtue and of wealth. He had the heart and he had the ability to redeem this messed up

situation. And, he was a near relative. He had not only the ability and the desire, but he obtained the authority.

We have all lived in the land of Moab spiritually. We have wandered from God, living according to our own ways, and have introduced sin and dysfunction into our family lines.

The good news is that if we recognize the error of our ways and return to Bethlehem (Jesus) He possesses the ability to fix up our messed up situation.

Perhaps our younger families have not seen the full effects of remaining in Moab, but I promise you that our older couples, who have raised families, they would implore you today to leave that place and return home to the Lord before it's too late.

Generations are in the balance. The consequence of remaining in Moab is too severe to risk.

Can we really afford to remain in the land of Moab? Moab claims our children and our families. Naomi buried a husband and two sons in Moab!

Moab for us is the dominion of death. It's a place outside of God's blessing and of God's best. It's a place where Satan bears deadly influence and brings bondage, decay and loss.

Today I want to challenge the father's to take your family by the hand and make a decision to move from Moab to Bethlehem.

Boaz is a picture of our Lord Jesus Christ. Boaz had the willingness, the wealth and the authority to redeem this messed up situation.

Jesus took upon Himself human flesh – He became a near relative to us! He had the willingness, He had the wealth, the ability and He had the authority to do so – and He did!

Will you take your family by the hand today and make a decision to leave the messed up land of Moab and flee to the raised up land of Bethlehem.

PRAYERS OF THE ELDERS

- Call for 25-year-or-more couples.
- Call young families forward for prayer.

THE FATHERS LEAD

Ruth 1:1-6 (NKJV) *“Now it came to pass, in the days when the judges ruled – (around 1,300 years before Christ), that there was a famine in the land. And a certain man of Bethlehem, Judah, went to dwell in the country of Moab, he and his wife and his two sons. 2 The name of the man was Elimelech, the name of his wife was Naomi, and the names of his*

*two sons were Mahlon and Chilion—
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Now they took wives of the women of Moab:
the name of the one was Orpah, and the name
of the other Ruth. And they dwelt there about
ten years. 5 Then both Mahlon and Chilion
also died; so the woman survived her two sons
and her husband.”*

We began last Sunday to consider how we
might connect to the resurrection power of
Christ to see our families transformed, from
“*Messed Up to Raised Up!*”

Raising a family has been challenging for as
long as there have been families. The challenges
couples face include:

- Financial provision...

- Marital harmony...
- Education...
- Career paths...
- Spirituality...
- Juggling family, work, intimacy and spiritual matters...
- Protection from destructive material and relationships...

The American Psychological Association on its website notes:

“Marriage and divorce are both common experiences. In Western cultures, more than 90 percent of people marry by age 50. Healthy marriages are good for couples’ mental and physical health. They are also good for children; growing up in a happy home protects children from mental, physical, educational and social problems. However, about 40 to 50 percent of married couples in the United States

divorce. The divorce rate for subsequent marriages is even higher.”

Last Sunday, we considered that the external pressures of the world can move us toward unhealthy choices in the leadership of our family.

The Word of God teaches us that the husband is the God-ordained head of the home. He is responsible for the provision, care and nurture of the family under his headship.

Elimelech, when faced with the challenges of famine, led his family to seek refuge in the land of Moab.

We discussed last week how Moab had been a perennial adversary of Israel and was known for its pagan worship. The results of his decision were disastrous.

His widow Naomi was left to lament upon her eventual return to Israel. Ruth 1:21 (NKJV) ***“I went out full, but the Lord has brought me home again empty.”***

As husbands, we bear the role of headship in the family. Headship does not mean “dictatorship.” It means being responsible for the wellbeing of those under your care.

The meaning of the word responsibility according to Dictionary.com: *The state or fact of being responsible, answerable, or accountable for something within one's power, control, or management.*

The husband is in authority over the family. He is also accountable to God for what he did with what he has. (Story of talking to a pastor – *“Whatever you allow at God’s house, He will allow at your house!”*) With authority comes responsibility! Ephesians 5:22-33 (NKJV)

“Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord. 23 For the husband is head of the wife, as also Christ is head of the church; and He is the Savior of the body. 24 Therefore, just as the church is subject to Christ, so let the wives be to their own husbands in everything. 25 Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ also loved the church and gave Himself for her, 26 that He might sanctify and cleanse her with the washing of water by the word, 27 that He might present her to Himself a glorious church, not having spot or wrinkle or any such thing, but that she should be holy and without blemish. 28 So husbands ought to love their own wives as their own bodies; he who loves his wife loves himself. 29 For no one ever hated his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it, just as the Lord does the church. 30 For we are members of His body, of His flesh and of His bones. 31 “For this reason a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two shall become

one flesh.” 32 This is a great mystery, but I speak concerning Christ and the church. 33 Nevertheless let each one of you in particular so love his own wife as himself, and let the wife see that she respects her husband.” A Godly husband should focus on three things with regard to his wife and family:

- Love them... (*“As Christ loved the church.”*) I am sure Elimelech loved Naomi but in his haste to take the course of least resistance he failed to *“Give himself for her.”*
- Sanctify and cleanse them... (With the blood and the word) Elimelech probably adored his sons but he placed them in harms way in his irresponsible effort to make a living.
- Present them... Elimelech led his family into the teeth disaster. He became a failed father and husband. (We will one day stand

before God and give account for how we led our families)

This idea of headship in no way carries with it the idea of individual superiority. No more than we think a teacher is superior to his students, but he or she is responsible for the conduct of that classroom and to work for the advancement of those pupils.

So also, a Christian husband and father is to work for the provision, orderliness, spirituality and advancement of his family.

If the story of Ruth and Naomi were to have ended at chapter one, what a sad and tragic tale it would have been, but the story does not end there!

Naomi heard, while in Moab, that God had visited Israel by giving them bread. After ten

years of hell in Moab, she decided it was time to head home.

Ruth, with loving devotion toward Naomi, joined Naomi on her return to Israel and committed herself to become a worshiper of God.

Her attitude and actions caught the eye of Boaz, a wealthy man who owned a field wherein Ruth just so happened, by the providence of God, to work and glean. Ruth 2:1 (NKJV) ***“There was a relative of Naomi’s husband, a man of great wealth, of the family of Elimelech. His name was Boaz.”***

Learning of Boaz’ interest in Ruth, Naomi counseled Ruth so that she might seek his affections toward marriage.

For in those ancient times, it was the custom that a near male relative ought to marry the

widow of his near relative and raise up children by her to continue the dead man's family line and ancestral inheritance.

Gentlemen, notice how Boaz made a play for Ruth: (Ruth 3:11-13)

- He testified to her virtuous lifestyle...
- He removed all the hindrances... (There was a closer relative that had the right to marry Ruth but Boaz overcame the hurdle)
- He romanced her...
- He put a ring on her finger...
- He covered her with the umbrella of his covering...
- He shared his wealth with her and her mother-on-law... (You marry the whole family)

I want you to notice the picture of Christ that we see in the actions of Boaz...

- He had the willingness to redeem...

- He had the wealth/ability to redeem...
- He sought the authority to redeem...

Gentlemen, the questions today are simple but significant:

- Will we willingly assume our God-ordained responsibility to lead, love and care for our family?
- Will we labor to become successful financially and spiritually to provide for the care of our family?
- Will we submit to God so that we might walk in His divine power and authority to lead and care for our family?

A WOMAN OF VIRTUE

Ruth 1:1-6 (NKJV) *“Now it came to pass, in the days when the judges ruled – (around 1,300 years before Christ), that there was a famine in the land. And a certain man of*

Bethlehem, Judah, went to dwell in the country of Moab, he and his wife and his two sons. 2 The name of the man was Elimelech, the name of his wife was Naomi, and the names of his two sons were Mahlon and Chilion—Ephrathites of Bethlehem, Judah. And they went to the country of Moab and remained there. 3 Then Elimelech, Naomi’s husband, died; and she was left, and her two sons. 4 Now they took wives of the women of Moab: the name of the one was Orpah, and the name of the other Ruth. And they dwelt there about ten years. 5 Then both Mahlon and Chilion also died; so the woman survived her two sons and her husband.”

We began this series on Easter Sunday by considering how we might connect to the resurrection power of Christ to see ourselves and our families transformed, “*From Messed Up to Raised Up!*”

It has always been challenging to raise a family.
It's even harder to raise a godly family today.

The battle that we face includes:

- The pressure to conform to a world system that is amoral...
- Immoral media and entertainment...
- Normalization of the gay lifestyle...
- Approval of transgendered individuals...
- A society that is attempting to redefine marriage...
- Educational systems that resist anything that recognizes God as creator...
- Religious leaders that call good bad and bad good...

These past two Sundays we have considered how the external pressures of the world can move us toward unhealthy choices in the leadership of our family.

We saw last week that when the head of the family, the husband, reacts with spiritual weakness to external pressures and temptations, it can create great challenges and bring great harm to the family.

This week, we will consider how the wife, by her godly and virtuous behavior, can set the stage for redemption and generational blessing!

Elimelech's decision to lead his family into Moab, a place of pagan worship and a people who had been the perennial adversaries of Israel, brought severe tragedy and hardship upon the family.

The story would be so sad and discouraging if it ended there. But it doesn't! Because of a decision on the part of Naomi, this family would soon experience God's salvation and produce unimaginable fruit and blessing!

Following the deaths of her husband and two sons and ten years in Moab, Naomi heard that God had visited His people Israel by providing food – a break in the famine. It was high time to head home.

Look closely to the actions of Naomi as she decided to forsake Moab for Bethlehem... Ruth 1:8-14 (NKJV) *“And Naomi said to her two daughters-in-law, “Go, return each to her mother’s house. The Lord deal kindly with you, as you have dealt with the dead and with me. 9 The Lord grant that you may find rest, each in the house of her husband - (find a new husband).” So she kissed them, and they lifted up their voices and wept. 10 And they said to her, “Surely we will return with you to your people.” 11 But Naomi said, “Turn back, my daughters; why will you go with me? ... No, my daughters; for it grieves me very much for your sakes that the hand of the Lord has gone out against me!” 14 Then they lifted up their*

voices and wept again; and Orpah kissed her mother-in-law, but Ruth clung to her.”

Orpah did the reasonable thing and returned to her family and to her people. But Ruth “***clung***” to Naomi in loving devotion, despite Naomi’s concern that she had nothing more to offer her.

Listen to these beautiful words... Ruth 1:16-17 (NKJV) ***“But Ruth said: “Entreat me not to leave you, Or to turn back from following after you; For wherever you go, I will go; And wherever you lodge, I will lodge; Your people shall be my people, And your God, my God. 17 Where you die, I will die, And there will I be buried. The Lord do so to me, and more also, If anything but death parts you and me.”***

What a beautiful expression of love and devotion! What a wonderful confession of faith and devotion to Naomi and to the God of Israel.

It's the decision on Naomi to put Moab in her rear view mirror and the love and devotion of Ruth that sets the stage for the great redemption that is to follow.

Boaz, a wealthy near relative of Naomi took notice of Ruth's diligent work gleaning in the fields to provide for herself and Naomi.

Several things caught the attention of Boaz:

- Her willingness to work hard... (He left her handfuls on purpose)
- Her stellar character... (He noticed how she acted and dressed)
- Her devotion to her mother in law...
- Her willingness to embrace the land and God of her mother in law...

Boaz declared, Ruth 3:11 (NKJV) ***“And now, my daughter, do not fear. I will do for you all***

that you request, for all the people of my town know that you are a virtuous woman.”

The Apostle Peter affirms the spiritual power that a wife possesses to bring the grace and presence of God into her home. 1 Peter 3:1-6 (NKJV) ***“Wives, likewise, be submissive to your own husbands, that even if some do not obey the word, they, without a word, may be won by the conduct of their wives, 2 when they observe your chaste conduct accompanied by fear. 3 Do not let your adornment be merely outward—arranging the hair, wearing gold, or putting on fine apparel— 4 rather let it be the hidden person of the heart, with the incorruptible beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit, which is very precious in the sight of God. 5 For in this manner, in former times, the holy women who trusted in God also adorned themselves, being submissive to their own husbands, 6 as Sarah obeyed Abraham, calling him lord, whose***

daughters you are if you do good and are not afraid with any terror.”

We spoke at length last week about the husband's responsibility of leadership in the family. A role each Christian husband is to exercise through sacrificial love.

Peter and Paul both commend to us the importance of a wife showing R-E-S-P-E-C-T to her husband. Paul says, ***“As unto the Lord.”*** This does not mean the husband is his wife's god. It means the wife gives respect to her husband as an offering to the Lord.

Peter states that ***“fear,”*** (respect) coupled with ***“chaste behavior”*** has the power to win an unbelieving husband to salvation and by implication, to wield great influence on a godly husband.

Chaste behavior refers to purity of motives and of good moral behavior. It speaks of walking in holiness – modeling godly character.

Peter carries it further, commending a “*gentle*” and “*quiet*” spirit.

- Gentle... The Holman Bible Dictionary notes that this refers to humility. It is not weakness or passivity – it is controlled power.
- Quiet... Keeping one’s seat. Remaining still and at peace.

Ladies, listen to what the Word has to say about a contentious woman. Proverbs 19:13 (NKJV) “*A foolish son is the ruin of his father, And the contentions of a wife are a continual dripping.* One Bible commentator has this to say: “*An obstinate, argumentative woman is like a leak so unrelenting that one has to run from it or go mad.*”

According to Solomon (The wisest man) there are two ways to devastate a man:

- To have an ungodly son...
- To have an irritating wife...

Listen to some other comments by Solomon on this subject:

- Proverbs 21:9 (NKJV) ***“Better to dwell in a corner of a housetop, Than in a house shared with a contentious woman.”***
- Proverbs 21:19 (NKJV) ***“Better to dwell in the wilderness than with a contentious and angry woman.”***
- Proverbs 27:15-16 (NKJV) ***“A continual dripping on a very rainy day and a contentious woman are alike, whoever restrains her restrains the wind, and grasps oil with his right hand.”***

A wife who behaves the way these proverbs describe is not adorning herself with godliness.

A wife who behaves this way is not likely to win the love and admiration of her husband or to be a positive influence on her children.

There are potential fears for a Christian woman who seeks to live as Peter describes.

- What if her husband is not being the godly example that he is supposed to be?
- What if she sees traits in her husband that concern her?
- What if she thinks her husband has a track record of failed decision-making?

The answer to this is that the wife is to submit to her husband unless doing so violates the Word of God! This is not to say that she cannot have an opinion or exert influence. She must exert influence but to do it in a Christ like way.

Ruth's virtue, godliness, diligence and walk of faith resulted in the redemption of a family line

and generational blessing. Ruth 4:13-17 (NKJV)
“So Boaz took Ruth and she became his wife; and when he went in to her, the Lord gave her conception, and she bore a son. 14 Then the women said to Naomi, “Blessed be the Lord, who has not left you this day without a close relative; and may his name be famous in Israel! 15 And may he be to you a restorer of life and a nourisher of your old age; for your daughter-in-law, who loves you, who is better to you than seven sons, has borne him.” ... 17 Also the neighbor women gave him a name, saying, “There is a son born to Naomi.” And they called his name Obed. He is the father of Jesse, the father of David.”

Matthew chapter one tells us ***“Boaz begot Obed by Ruth, and that Obed became the father of King David.”*** He traces this family line all the way to our Lord Jesus Christ, the ***“Son of David.”***

God can and will bring redemption and generational blessing through the heart and influence of a godly woman!

I want to say to every woman in the house that you have more power to persuade your husband and family in a godly way than does any other member of the family.

Use your influence for the sake of righteousness and resist walking in a Jezebel spirit.

CHILDREN

A HERITAGE FROM THE LORD

Ruth 1:1-6 (NKJV) “Now it came to pass, in the days when the judges ruled – (around 1,300 years before Christ), that there was a famine in the land. And a certain man of Bethlehem, Judah, went to dwell in the country of Moab, he and his wife and his two sons. 2 The name of the man was Elimelech, the name

of his wife was Naomi, and the names of his two sons were Mahlon and Chilion—Ephrathites of Bethlehem, Judah. And they went to the country of Moab and remained there. 3 Then Elimelech, Naomi’s husband, died; and she was left, and her two sons. 4 Now they took wives of the women of Moab: the name of the one was Orpah, and the name of the other Ruth. And they dwelt there about ten years. 5 Then both Mahlon and Chilion also died; so the woman survived her two sons and her husband.”

We began this series on Easter Sunday by considering how we might connect to the resurrection power of Christ to see ourselves and our families transformed from “*Messed Up to Raised Up!*”

It has always been challenging to raise a family! The challenge has been made exponentially more difficult as a result of a society flooded

with immoral media and entertainment that is rebelling against God's standards for sexual behavior.

These past three Sundays we have considered how external and worldly pressures can move us toward unhealthy choices in the leadership of our family.

We've learned that when the head of the family, represented by Elimelech, reacts with spiritual weakness to external pressures and temptations, it creates great challenges and brings great harm to the family unit.

We've learned how the wife, represented by Naomi and her godly behavior and virtue becomes the conduit for God's restoration and blessing, great deliverance and restoration can occur.

This week, we will consider the goal and the importance of raising up godly offspring.

Elimelech's decision to lead his family into Moab, a place of pagan worship and a people who had been the perennial adversaries of Israel, brought severe tragedy and hardship upon the family.

These past three weeks we have talked about Elimelech, Boaz and Ruth. But it's apparent as you read the book of Ruth the story unfolds from the perspective of Naomi, the family matriarch.

Upon hearing that God had broken the famine for His people Israel, and Naomi and Ruth decided to return to Bethlehem, Naomi was made painfully aware that the cold hard realities of ten years in Moab had changed her life forever. *Ruth 1:19-20 (NKJV)* ***“Now the two of them went until they came to Bethlehem. And***

it happened, when they had come to Bethlehem, that the city was excited because of them; and the women said, “Is this Naomi?” But she said to them, “Do not call me Naomi – (meaning: Pleasant); but call me Mara – (meaning: Bitter), for the Almighty has dealt very bitterly with me. I went out full, and the Lord has brought me home again empty. Why do you call me Naomi, since the Lord has testified against me, and the Almighty has afflicted me?” Here Naomi appears to have been grounded in the sovereignty of God – a conviction that her life and experiences were under His authority, but her outlook was one of despair. Her heart was broken and her hopes for the future appeared dim.

Remember, Naomi and Elimelech and Naomi left Bethlehem because of the famine (Lack) but upon her return she said, *“I went out full and have come back empty.”* Let me remind us, the

worst day with God's blessing is better than the best day without it.

It's no wonder. Moab – the world – has that affect upon us. Living outside of God's will eventually takes a toll upon us and tends to leave our hearts bitter and our dreams fading.

Naomi's time in Moab, and the suffering which it brought, made her to feel she no longer had, nor probably deserved the blessing of God. Now suddenly her fortunes were about to change through the godly love and virtue of Ruth and the redemptive heart of Boaz. God had a better plan for Naomi and Ruth than they could have imagined. You may feel that your future is bleak but I promise you that God has a better plan in mind. I am about to prophecy to someone *“God is about to visit you with His blessing in due season.”*

The channel of God's blessing to Naomi and even down to our generation today was the marriage of Ruth and Boaz. Ruth 4:14 (NKJV) ***“So Boaz took Ruth and she became his wife; and when he went in to her, the Lord gave her conception, and she bore a son. Then the women said to Naomi, “Blessed be the Lord, who has not left you this day without a close relative; and may his name be famous in Israel! And may he be to you a restorer of life and a nourisher of your old age; for your daughter-in-law who loves you, who is better to you than seven sons, has borne him.” ... Also the neighbor women gave him a name, saying, “There is a son (grandson) born to Naomi.” And they called his name Obed. He is the father of Jesse, the father of David.”***

David became Israel's great king and the ancestor of our Lord Jesus Christ, who among other titles bears the title ***“The Son of David.”***

God used the first marriage – that of Adam and Eve – to launch the human race and His plan for redemption.

God used the marriage of Ruth and Boaz to rescue the fortunes of Naomi and continue forward His plan of redemption.

God intends to use our marriages to influence the next generation and carry forward His kingdom purposes.

Let us be encouraged that our faithful commitment to our marriages will lay the foundation to raise godly children.

God's plan for children is that they will receive the loving discipline of God-fearing parents, along with active and aggressive exposure to the Word of God and the presence of God.

Ephesians 6:1-2 (NKJV) ***“Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right. 2 “Honor***

your father and mother,” which is the first commandment with promise: 3 “that it may be well with you and you may live long on the earth.”⁴ And you, fathers, do not provoke your children to wrath, but bring them up in the training and admonition of the Lord.”

Children are called upon to obey, and must be made to obey, so that God’s promise of blessing may be theirs. (Screaming child on an airplane)

Fathers are called upon to take deliberate and sufficient action to lead their children to Christ. Notice the words ***“bring them up in the training and admonition of the Lord.”***

To the single mothers (and fathers), I say avail yourselves of the family of God so that He may bring godly mentors and relationships to help support you in bringing up your children.

When Ruth and Boaz discovered that they were pregnant the women said that this child would be better for Naomi ***“Than seven sons.”***

Remember, Naomi lost a husband and two sons in Moab. The Lord blessed her with a gift she never thought she would have, a grandchild to hold!

Through this blessing Naomi became the great-great grandmother of King David and an ancestor of Jesus.

Let me finish this series by talking about a parent’s responsibility with regard to children:

- The parents are to lead the home, not the children... (***“Train up a child in the way they should go...”***)
- The parents are to be the disciplinarians... (Sometimes you can’t be the parent and the best friend – Be the parent)

- The parents are to decide where the children can go and whom they go with... (My experience with Jason and Larissa)
- The parents are to set the spiritual direction of the family... (Joshua – “*As for me and my house we will serve the Lord*”)

CONCLUSION:

I believe in household salvation! The only thing you can take to Heaven with you is your family! (My family meetings...)

Deuteronomy 5:16 (NKJV) “*Honor your father and your mother, as the Lord your God has commanded you, that your days may be long, and that it may be well with you in the land which the Lord your God is giving you.*” Two things are promised to obedient children who honor their parents:

- You can expect the best from the world you live in....

- You can expect long life... (I thought when I was growing up that this scripture meant that if you obeyed your parents they would not kill you)

I pray this prayer over my family and every person connected to CT Church every day:
(PLACE THIS PRAYER ON THE SCREEN AND LEAVE IT UP UNTIL THE END OF THE SERVICE)

*“I plead the blood of Jesus over _____.
I pray that blood will destroy everything that is unlike itself. Protect them and provide for them, make a way where there seems to be no way. Lay Your hand upon them, bless them indeed, enlarge their territory, may their life not cause pain. Bless them with all the blessing of the house of Obed Edom as the Ark of the Lord rested there. May no plague come near their dwelling, may no evil thing befall them. Keep them in all their ways, may they acknowledge*

You in everything they do. Keep them in Your will all the days of their lives. I pray that not one person in their family line perish, ever! I declare and decree household salvation, in Jesus name, Amen!”